THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

The law of triviality

Teams spend the most time on the smallest decisions

swipe →

Ivan Rykov

Reactor: 2½ minutes
Bike shed: 45 minutes



NUCLEAR REACTOR

2:30 min

approved



BIKE SHED

45:00 min

still debating

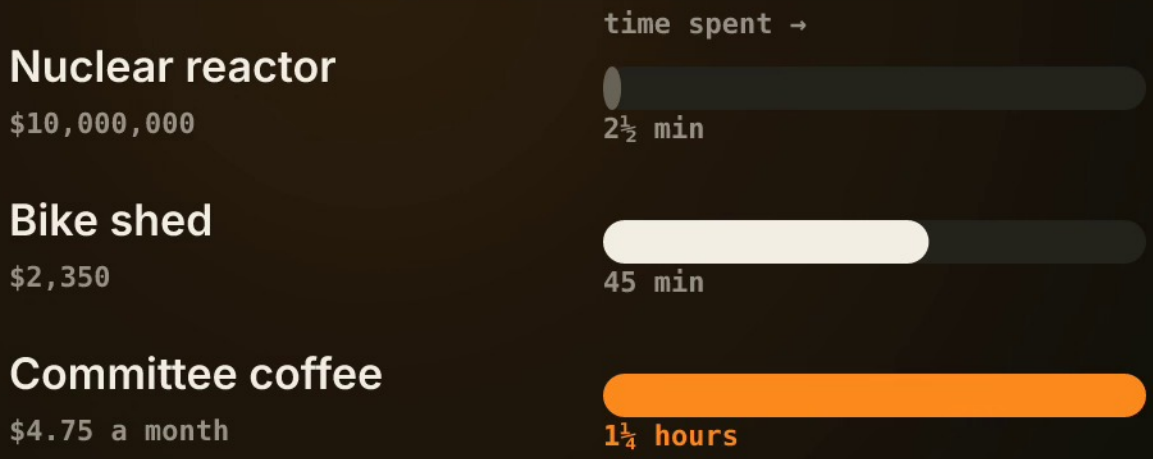
The story is from 1957

C. Northcote Parkinson's committee, a satire

The law of triviality

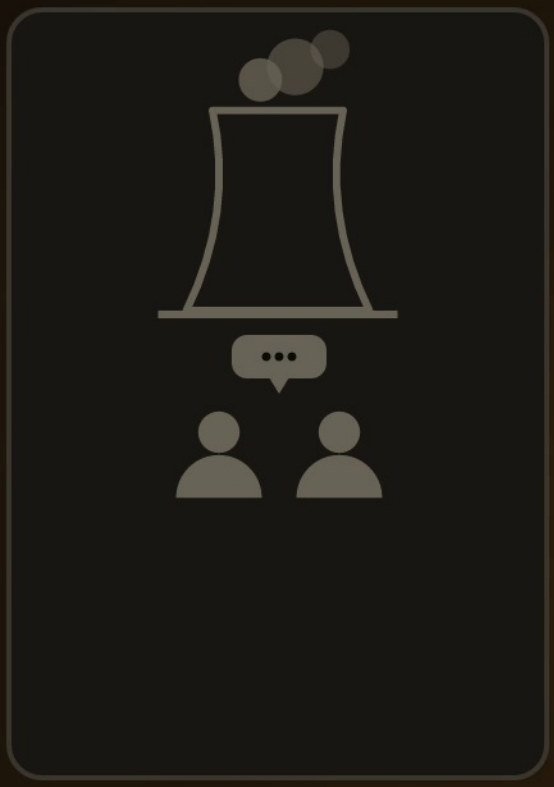
C. Northcote Parkinson · 1957 · the same Parkinson

> “The time spent on any item of the agenda will be in inverse proportion to the sum involved”



Parkinson’s Law, 1957 · US edition, so the figures are in dollars

Hard topics: quiet
Easy ones: loud





Everyone can picture a bike shed

illustration

1999: it gets a name

From: Poul-Henning Kamp
Date: Sat, 2 Oct 1999
Subject: A bike shed (any colour will do) on greener grass...

"anyone can build one of those over a weekend"

why a bike shed draws every opinion

the trigger: fractional seconds in sleep(1)

bikeshedding (noun)

FreeBSD mailing list · Kamp made the term famous, from Parkinson's example

Your team does it too

`userName → username?`
variable naming
50 comments

`migration: new data model`
the part that is hard to undo
0 comments

Submit



the colour debate

illustration

Small topics eat the meeting

a one-hour meeting

Variable naming — 20 min

Button colour — 20 min

Code style — 15 min

Architecture decision — 5 min

The big decision gets five tired minutes

illustration

Match the effort to the risk

SMALL DECISION

One owner, a short time box

decide in five minutes, move on

STYLE

A linter and a style guide

the tool decides, not the meeting

BIG DECISION

A written proposal: RFC or ADR

read before the meeting by the right people

Spend attention on the risk



Not on how easy the topic is

TAKEAWAY

Spend attention on the risk Not on how easy the topic is

Sources: C. Northcote Parkinson, 1957 · Poul-Henning Kamp, FreeBSD, 1999

next: Cunningham's law